

Font Selection Tips

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There was once just typeset, and the font was what the typesetter had in stock for cast letters.



Then came the internet, and anyone could create a font. Today, programs come with long lists of font options, and you can easily grow these by licensing even more- some free, some cheap, and custom can get expensive.

How do you choose?



First, consider the content that the font will be used in:

- Instruction Manual: Keep it simple, sans-serif styles like Helvetica or Arial.
- Textbooks & Novels: Use a serif font, which helps with readability in long text.
- Child Website: Fun and decorative fonts like Comic Sans, just keep it fun.
- Websites: A family of sans-serif fonts, such as Helvetica or Arial.
- Legal document: Traditional formal serif fonts such as Garamond or Bookman.
- Public Signs: Easy to read from a distance, sans-serif fonts like Futura or Helvetica.
- Brand Advertising: Unique, some custom, or bold decorative elements to grab attention.

Sand or Sans?



Not Sand, drop the “d” for Sans. The watch shows Roman numerals, likely a Display font. Our most used fonts are Serif and Sans-Serif.

- Serif: The heritage fonts, generally conveying stability and trust. Identified by the projections or “feet” at the end of strokes. These feet help the eye follow long text runs in books.
 - Times New Roman, Garamond, *or* Georgia
- Sans-Serif: Sans is French for “without”, so lacking in extra strokes. This is considered the modern, clean font used for text on most websites.
 - Helvetica, Arial, *or* Futura
- Script: This is known to be elegant and nostalgic; use with caution for younger audiences.
 - *Brush Script* *or* *Lucida Calligraphy*
- Display: A Bold script used for campaigns, signage, but too much can overwhelm. This is an area where organizations may choose to create a custom font tied to their Brand.
 - **Impact, Broadway,** *or* **ENGRAVERS**

Selecting a font depends on many factors, such as the media used, the level of readability required, the desired impact, and the emotion we want to impart to the target audience. Like color, fonts can also involve demographic and cultural considerations, so the resulting impact is not surprising. Testing with target audiences is always advised, especially with unique and custom fonts. Remember in design, one size does not always fit everyone, and multiple versions of a marketing piece may be needed for different languages, regions, ages, or cultures. Do not assume that they will always look the same from a distance.